strength-and-conditioning coach. But would more speed have made me a better player? I don't think so. I concentrated on long-distance running, to enhance my endurance.

Maybe the modern teenage boy needs a little bit more freedom to be himself, to think for himself, but there are obvious sporting examples they can follow. The common denominator, linking Owen Farrell to David Beckham, Rory McIlroy to Graham Gooch, across the generations, is that they were there, working, when everyone else had gone home. That's why they are, or were, the best.

I've worked sixteen-hour days on the family farm in Bedfordshire, doing the job until it is done. There's not that much difference, in terms of mindset, from reporting to pre-breakfast sessions with Goochy when I was taken on by Essex. I lapped up every word he said. The end, the reward of my first professional contract, paying £667 monthly after tax, justified the means.

I hadn't yet learned to drive during my first year as a pro – not that I could have afforded a car – and Mum and Dad weren't prepared to be taxi drivers, so that meant catching a bus at 6.43 a.m. and a connecting train to Chelmsford at 7.15. Provided public transport didn't let me down, I'd be at the ground for eight. I'd grab breakfast, spend two hours in the gym, at least two hours batting, and then do the reverse commute.

I was knackered. I'd sleep for two hours in mid-afternoon, have an early dinner and then go back to bed. With hindsight, I was adjusting to the demands of professional sport. The transition from emerging player, scorer of seventeen centuries, two double-hundreds and 4,396 runs at an average of 87.90, to first team wannabe was stark.

A county second team is a team in name only, a melting pot of players with different career trajectories and variable levels of motivation. It can be a shared adventure – there was an obvious affinity with Will Jefferson, James Foster and Ravi Bopara, because we were on similar pathways – but it is essentially a selfish experience. Everything is seen through the prism of your own progression.

I was fortunate in sharing a dressing room with Barry Hyam, a senior pro with a rare generosity of spirit. A second-team stalwart, who played sixty-one first-class games in nine years from 1993, he was a huge source of encouragement and advice. It is no surprise he has developed into a